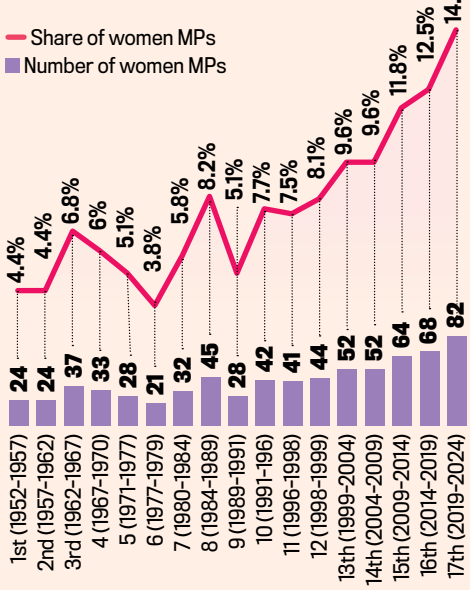
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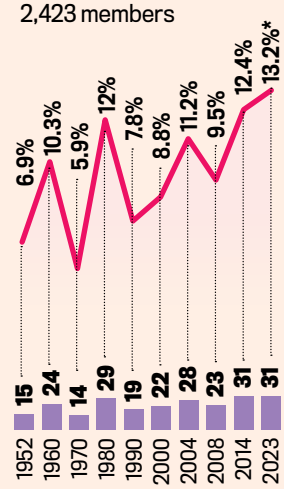
WOMEN MEMBERS IN LOK SABHA

The share of women in the Lok Sabha has been gradually increasing since the beginning of this century, but they still don't account for even a fifth of the total members



WOMEN MEMBERS IN RAJYA SABHA

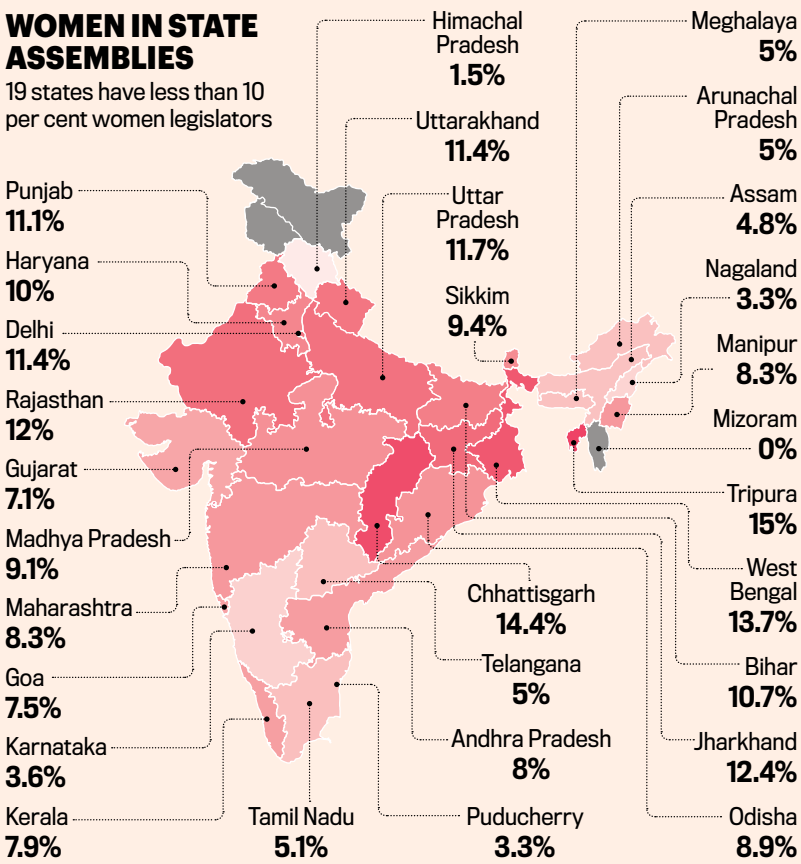
219 women have become members of the upper house since its first sitting in 1952, accounting for 9 per cent of the total 2,423 members



*of current strength of 238 members

WOMEN IN STATE ASSEMBLIES

19 states have less than 10 per cent women legislators



mostly in north India, ended up with a greater number of seats in Parliament. To allay the fears of unequal political representation expressed by developed states, the Constitution was amended in 1976 to suspend delimitation until 2001. Another amendment in 2001 postponed it by 25 years, to be done based on the first Census after 2026.

That first Census after 2026 will be due in 2031. However, since Covid-19 put paid to the 2021 exercise, the Union government may well decide to conduct the pending Census in 2026. In that case, the delimitation exercise, which is scheduled after 2026, will be carried out on the basis of the Census in 2026. Union home minister Amit Shah indicated as much when he said that the government that assumes office after the 2024 general election will conduct both the Census and the delimitation, completing both exercises, hopefully, by 2029. That could then pave the way for the implementation of women's reservation by 2029. Political observers, however, caution this could be more time-consuming than is being projected. In 2002, when a new Delimitation Act was passed to redraw the existing number of parliamentary/ assembly constituencies on the basis of the 2001 Census, it took the delimitation commission nearly two and a half years to acquire the data to conduct the exercise. The delimitation effort post-2026 is also likely to face legal challenges, particularly from the southern states that may lose constituencies in a population-based delimitation exercise. There is a fear that southern states where the population is less will be allotted lesser seats compared to some northern states where population growth is much higher. All this may delay the delimitation exercise and eventually the implementation of the women's reservation bill to the 2034 election and beyond,

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY